

What Is the Book of Proverbs *For*?

Proverbs 1:1–7

Hi Mum. I've dropped my phone down the loo. This is my new number. Can you save it?

A few minutes later, a second message:

Bit awkward. I need to pay a bill today and my banking app won't work on the new phone. Could you send £450? I'll pay you back on Friday. Love you x

Thousands of parents in this country have had a text like that. Many of them paid. Not because they were stupid. It sounded just like their child – the right tone, the little kiss at the end – and love wants to help, and help quickly. Fraud is now the crime people in this country are most likely to meet. And it works because a confident voice turns up and nobody is there to say, *hang on a minute*.

The police advice is simple. Don't reply. Don't stare harder at the message. Ring the number you already know, and hear the real voice for yourself.

We're all easier to talk round than we think. And we're nowhere near as good as we imagine at telling a true voice from a false one.

Which brings us back to the big question of this series: **how would we know if we were actually wise?**

Last time we began to answer it. Do you remember my folder of certificates, every one marked by somebody else? The first part of the answer was: we wouldn't know – not by looking at ourselves. The book doesn't end with a certificate. It ends with a confession.

I promised we'd come back and work through these seven verses properly. So this morning we ask four things: whose book this is, who it's for, what it asks of us, and where it tells us to start.

But first, picture the people this was written for. A young Israelite, about to step out of his father's house into the busy city – the market, the law court, the city gate. Every one of those places is full of voices. Some want to help him; some want to use him. And he can't yet tell which is which. We're not so different.

Whose book is this? (verse 1)

The proverbs of Solomon son of David, king of Israel:

It's Solomon's book.

Anyone reading the Bible in order has met Solomon already, in the books of Kings. Solomon asked God for wisdom, and God gave it (1 Kings 3). Nobody in Israel's story was wiser.

But they also know how his story ended. 1 Kings 11 verse 3: "his wives led him astray." In old age his heart was turned away from the LORD.

So the very first line opens a gap. Here is the wisdom of Solomon. And here is the man who had that wisdom and still lost his way. We need to keep Solomon's *story* in mind as we read Solomon's *book*. We'll come back to it at the end.

So who is it written for?

Who is the book for? (verses 2–5)

Verses 2 to 6 hang together: “for attaining... for acquiring... for giving... for understanding.” Not separate topics – they all tell us what the book is *for*.

Look at the middle of it, verse 3:

for acquiring a disciplined and prudent life, doing what is right and just and fair;

“Doing what is right and just and fair” isn’t one more item on the list. It tells us *how* everything else on the list must be used. Cleverness can hurt people as easily as it helps them. A clever person can make a very good crook. So the book says: none of this counts unless it’s used to do right, to be fair, and to look after people.

Why does the book need to say that? Because of who it’s written for. Verse 4:

for giving prudence to the simple, knowledge and discretion to the young –

“The simple.” That’s the book’s own word for its readers. It doesn’t mean stupid. It means *open*. The door is always unlocked. Chapter 14 says it plainly: “A simple man believes anything.” He believes whoever spoke to him last.

And notice the verb: “for *giving*.” The book doesn’t tell the simple to try harder. It offers to give them what they haven’t got. *Prudence* – the good sense to spot a trap before you walk into it. And *discretion* – the ability to see what someone is really after.

Here's a surprise. In Hebrew, "prudence" is in the same word family as "crafty" – the word used for the snake in Genesis 3. The book takes the snake's sharpness and hands it, cleaned up, to innocent people. Jesus said much the same: "be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves" (Matthew 10:16).

A few verses later the book lets us hear a gang's recruitment speech in full. "Come along with us... we will get all sorts of valuable things... throw in your lot with us" (1:11–14). It sounds like friendship. It's a trap.

Then in chapter 9 the book does something even cleverer. Two women call out from two doors – Wisdom in verse 4, Folly in verse 16. And they say *exactly the same words to exactly the same person*:

"Let all who are simple come in here!" she says to those who lack judgment.

Two voices, two doors, one invitation. If we can't tell them apart, we'll walk through the wrong door. It's the "Hi Mum" text, three thousand years early.

Now look at verse 5. The NIV puts dashes round it, as if it's an interruption:

let the wise listen and add to their learning, and let the discerning get guidance –

But it isn't really an interruption. Verse 2 talked about "wisdom" and "understanding... insight." Verse 5 talks about "the wise" and "the discerning." In Hebrew, "understanding," "insight" and "discerning" all come from the same word family. So verse 2 opens a bracket, and verse 5 closes it.

So the book is for everyone – the easily-led at one end, the wise at the other. And the wise aren't ordered about. They're invited: *let* the wise listen and add to their learning.

And let me say plainly: I am not the wise man of verse 5, handing down wisdom to simple people below me. Verse 4 has named who this book is for. I'm in that group too.

So what does the book ask of us in return?

What will the book ask of us? (verse 6)

for understanding proverbs and parables, the sayings and riddles of the wise.

“Riddles.” It's the same Hebrew word used for Samson's riddle in Judges 14: “Out of the eater, something to eat.” Nobody could work it out for three days.

So the book tells us, in its own introduction, that it has to be **worked out**, not just obeyed.

Remember the two verses in chapter 26 that give opposite advice?

Do not answer a fool according to his folly, or you will be like him yourself. Answer a fool according to his folly, or he will be wise in his own eyes.

Which is right? Both. It depends on the fool and on the moment, and *you* have to work out which.

So we all need to learn how to read a proverb. Otherwise we'll read every proverb as either a promise or a rule – and both mistakes do real harm to real people.

Take 22:6:

Train a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not turn from it.

That is not a guarantee. I've watched it fail both ways. I know parents who raised their children with great care and much prayer, and those children have walked away. I know parents who were careless, and their children now love the Lord. And I know the ache of watching someone we have prayed for since before they could talk drift a little further off each year. Some of you know that ache better than I do.

If 22:6 is a guarantee, then every one of those parents is to blame. That's the damage a misread proverb does. It hands hurting parents a guilty verdict, when what they needed was something to pray.

Proverbs tells us how life *usually* works in God's world. It doesn't hand out guarantees.

So where do we start? Verse 7.

Where do we begin? (verse 7)

The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge, but fools despise wisdom and discipline.

Most of us can quote the first half. Hardly anyone quotes the second – yet the second half shows us what the first looks like in real life.

Look at the last three words: “wisdom and discipline.” Verse 2: “for attaining wisdom and discipline.” The same two words open the passage and close it. Verse 2 says: this is what the book gives. Verse 7 says: this is what fools turn down.

And notice what a fool is here. It isn't someone who can't do sums. It's an attitude. It's the person who has heard enough, thanks. Who doesn't need correcting. Who has checked himself over and is perfectly happy with what he found.

The fear of the LORD is the end of that attitude. To fear the LORD is to take God seriously: to be in awe of him, to trust him, and to let him correct us.

Verse 7 also stands on its own. There's no joining word in the Hebrew. It's dropped in like a foundation stone. Everything in verses 2 to 6 – doing what is right and fair, good sense for the easily-led, the skill to read a riddle – rests on this one stone.

And “beginning” doesn't mean the beginners' stage. It isn't “start here, then move on to the deeper stuff.” The Hebrew word means first in *importance* as well as first in *time* – the way we talk about *the main thing*.

The book proves that by its own shape. The fear of the LORD isn't left behind after chapter 1. It comes back at the end of the opening section, in 9:10. And it's still there in the last person the book praises, at 31:30:

Charm is deceptive, and beauty is fleeting; but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.

Thirty chapters later, and the fear of the LORD hasn't been outgrown. It's the foundation *and* the top of the building.

Look at 3:7:

Do not be wise in your own eyes; fear the LORD and shun evil.

The problem and the answer, side by side. How would we know if we were actually wise? Not by our own opinion of ourselves. *Never* by that.

As we saw last time, the book says this again and again: “wise in his own eyes.” And in 21:2 it tells us why:

All a man’s ways seem right to him, but the LORD weighs the heart.

In Hebrew it says: every man’s way is right *in his own eyes*.

That isn’t only about wicked people. It’s about all of us. The eyes we’d use to check ourselves are the very eyes that need checking. It’s like trying to find out whether your glasses are dirty by looking through them.

That’s why the answer isn’t to look harder at ourselves. We need to be weighed by someone else.

The King who does not judge by his eyes

Now turn with me to Isaiah 11. Isaiah is speaking about a King who will come from David’s family, a new shoot from an old stump. Verse 2:

The Spirit of the LORD will rest on him – the Spirit of wisdom and of understanding, the Spirit of counsel and of power, the Spirit of knowledge and of the fear of the LORD –

Listen: *wisdom* and *understanding* – from Proverbs 1:2. *Knowledge* and *the fear of the LORD* – from Proverbs 1:7. Every key word of our passage is there – and Isaiah rests them all on a King.

Then verse 3:

and he will delight in the fear of the LORD. He will not judge by what he sees with his eyes, or decide by what he hears with his ears;

This is the line to take home. *He will not judge by what he sees with his eyes.* In Hebrew, “his eyes” is the very same word that Proverbs keeps using: “right in his own eyes.”

Everyone in Proverbs judges by his own eyes. That’s the whole problem. But here is one man who doesn’t – because the Spirit of knowledge and of the fear of the LORD *rests* on him.

And look what follows in verse 4. *Because* he doesn’t judge by his eyes:

with righteousness he will judge the needy, with justice he will give decisions for the poor of the earth.

That’s exactly where Proverbs 1:3 put the weight: what is right and just and fair. Wisdom that doesn’t trust its own eyes can at last be trusted with people who can’t protect themselves. That’s the whole book coming home.

Notice too: the fear of the LORD comes twice. Back in chapter 7, King Ahaz was shaking with fear of the wrong things. Now a nation afraid of the wrong things is promised a King whose joy is the right fear.

So how would we know?

Verse 1 gives us a wise king whose wisdom didn’t hold. Verse 7 gives us the very thing he let go of. Isaiah promises a King on whom all those words rest, who delights in what Solomon lost, and who never judges by his eyes.

And Jesus tells us that one greater than Solomon has come. Matthew 12:42:

The Queen of the South will rise at the judgment with this generation and condemn it; for she came from the ends of the earth

to listen to Solomon's wisdom, and now one greater than Solomon is here.

Solomon's name is on the cover of this book, but he isn't its hero. He's its warning. Christ is its hero.

So – how would we know if we were actually wise?

This morning's answer is this: **we would start by admitting that we are the people this book is for.** Not the experts. The simple. The ones who can be talked round.

And that isn't bad news. Remember verse 4: “for *giving*.” Wisdom isn't a prize for the clever. It's a gift for people who know they need it. Next time, in chapter 2, we'll hear where that gift comes from: “For the LORD gives wisdom” (2:6).

For that young Israelite heading out into the city, this was good news. He didn't have to become clever enough to beat every voice at the gate. He had to fear the LORD, and listen to the voice that came from the LORD.

It's the same for us. If you're quietly sure of yourself this morning, hear this: you're the person most at risk. And if you know how quickly a confident voice can turn your head, hear this: this book was written for you. That's the gift.

If you're not yet a Christian, the claim here is worth weighing. It isn't that you'd be more religious if you feared the LORD. It's that you would *see more clearly than you do now*. A life that isn't built on the fear of the LORD isn't just less religious. It's less wise.

Think back to that text message. *Hi Mum*. The advice wasn't, “Study the message harder.” It was, “Ring the number you already know. Hear the real voice.”

This week many voices will speak to you – on your phone, at school, at work, in your own head. Folly uses the same words as Wisdom. We won't sort them out by staring harder.

But we have been given a voice we can trust. It belongs to the King who has never once judged by what he sees with his eyes. He isn't just a wise teacher. He is God's wisdom, given to us in person.

So stop trusting your own eyes. Fear the LORD. Go to the King, and let him give you what you haven't got. He gives wisdom to the simple. That is what this book is for.

Amen.

Scripture quotations are taken from the Holy Bible, New International Version (1984 edition).

Readings: Proverbs 1:1–7; 9:1–6, 13–18. Isaiah 11:1–5.

Summary for publication:

How would you know if you were actually wise? Proverbs opens by naming its readers – not the experts, but “the simple”: people easily talked round, who believe whoever spoke last. Solomon's name is on the cover, but he is the book's warning, not its hero. This sermon works through Proverbs 1:1–7 to its foundation stone, the fear of the LORD, and lands on Isaiah's promised King – the one who does not judge by what he sees with his eyes.